

be finished in two-to-three hours also accelerate the trend, says Pai. "Moonlighting is going to be a fact of life because this industry has become global." Abhishek Rungta, Founder & CEO of Kolkata-based mid-sized IT services firm Indus Net Technologies, admits that they can neither gauge the extent of the trend, nor can they practically verify if these are non-competitive in nature. "It's like a non-regulated market. You cannot close it, but it will be best if you can regulate it through basic framework and disclosures." The firm plans to introduce guidelines about moonlighting roles that will not hurt its business.

The practice is not limited to IT services firms alone; almost every knowledge- and services-based industry has moonlighting going on in some degree. Freelancing portals are brimming with listings for creative work such as design, writing and translation. Even non-creative service-based roles such as HR, finance, sales and marketing, and legal skills are in demand on these sites. The education sector is especially prone to it. Mohit C., a school administrator, says many teachers conduct private tuitions after school hours, despite the conflict of interest between the two jobs.

One of the tenets of the edtech business model is work flexibility for teachers. "If our workforce gets involved in parallel engagement opportunities, it will deviate them from their goal of assisting learners," says upGrad CHRO Saurabh Deep Singla. The edtech platform says it doesn't plan to introduce a moonlighting policy for external engagements. Instead, it has built in-house engagement sessions for their teachers to acquire new skills and become internal subject matter experts on academic subjects during non-working hours.

Roles that do not require the employee's physical presence throughout the day are more likely to lend themselves to moonlighting, says Qness Corp's Sivaram. "Sales executives take up a night shift in other industries, a retail employee could be working at exhibition centres

SIDE GIGS APLENTY

1

SOFTWARE TESTING AUTOMATION TRAINER

► \$21-\$33/hour

► Project requirement: 1-3 months, less than 30 hours/week

2

DEVOPS MANAGER

► \$25-\$40/hour

► Project requirement: 3 months, less than 30 hours/week

3

SALESFORCE ARCHITECT

► \$25-\$30/hour

► Project requirement: 6 months, less than 30 hours/week

4

GRAPHIC/UI/UX DESIGNER

► \$20-\$50/hour

► Project requirement: 1-3 months, less than 30 hours/week

5

MARKETING MANAGER

► \$20-\$30/hour

► Project requirement: More than 6 months, less than 30 hours/week

SOURCE FREELANCE JOB LISTING PLATFORMS

after shift hours, social media marketers work for different brands and companies, and the engineering technology sector has an element of moonlighting involving UI/UX designers and auto designers."

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BUT MOONLIGHTING'S SIGNIFICANCE gets amplified in the IT services industry, a high-competition sector that is the largest employer of the country's white-collar workforce. Ensuring both client data protection and talent retention are paramount, especially to remain attractive to a changed workforce in a post-pandemic, post-WFH era. But the industry is yet to arrive at a consensus on what moonlighting is and what exactly is prohibited because it was not a serious problem so far. Besides, they have little reference to take from the global tech giants given cultural and legal differences, recruiters say. "Moonlighting as a structural problem is discussed more in India than globally because the hybrid technology workforce is obviously larger in India. Globally, firms may not be using the term 'moonlighting', but they have clear-cut policies on dual employment, etc. In the US, if you make an offer to an employee and he accepts that offer, it is 99 per cent likely that the employee will join. In India, if you make an offer to an employee, you hope that he joins," says Sivaram.

Ballurkar says the employee is also a victim of lack of clarity: "Tremendous clarity on what the contract says will enable employees to have complete free will and a guilt-free approach." Calling it a solvable problem, he says the IT bellwethers will set the new best practices for an industry that will become more outcome- and KPI-based in job descriptions and appraisals. "Efforts are good but outcome is better—that will be the approach," he says.

Sangeeta Gupta, Senior VP and Chief Strategy Officer at the IT-BPM industry's trade association Nasscom, says they recommend to companies that they strengthen their onboarding process (including background